away. It was always going to happen at some stage, and it is inevitably a hold-your-breath moment. It takes a while to rebalance your life.

There are differences, though my life with Alice has always been slightly disorganized, in being here, there and everywhere. I still bounce between cricket and the farm, the kids and cricket, and sometimes wonder where I am going to land. I'm around for odd days, but I'm still dancing to the rhythms of a cricket season.

Playing for Essex is distinctive, because you are in performance mode the whole time. That's unlike playing for England, where you are in preparation mode for most of the time. Test cricket has a different cadence. You might have a month off after a tour, have a couple of games for your county to start ticking over, and then go into the rituals of another series. You become used to the routine of a five-day Test match being sandwiched between separate bursts of two to three days' preparation. You must deal with the intensity of competition, chill out briefly, and build yourself up to do it all again. It is a life of structured highs and lows. Compared to that, in county cricket you are flatlining.

That's taken a while to get used to, because I found the intensity in the international game surprisingly energizing. I'm not demeaning or disrespecting playing for Essex, because it is demanding in a different way. I'm still coming up against very good, extremely dedicated, consistently skilful players. The level is high, but not as severe.

This is the first time, since the age of twenty-one, that I am playing with the security of something other than a one-year deal. I have a three-year contract, so I'm no longer obliged to endure the 'what if?' scenario, which usually looms two or three months into a professional cricketer's summer. Even when I appeared settled with England, I went through the annual process of review and renewal. I no longer deal with the strategic uncertainty of living from tour to tour, central contract to central contract.

There can never be true stability at the highest level. The world may seem bigger when you step into the England team, but there are still obstacles to overcome, boundaries to be breached. A better pay structure carries the threat of complacency, but the more far-sighted player realizes that, by playing twenty-five Tests or fifty one-day internationals he can earn the sort of money that can substantially change his life.

Inevitably, exposure brings pressure. Your profile is higher, so more people want a piece of you. You must learn to read character, find a way of